

NTANDOMODS ICT DIPLOMA

MONTH 1

Computer Basics & Touch Typing

6-Month Full Diploma Programme

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Welcome to Month 1

Congratulations on starting the NtandoMods ICT Diploma. This is Month 1 of your 6-month journey. By the end of this diploma, you will have the computer skills needed to work in an office, run a business, or qualify for further education.

Month 1 covers the most important foundation: understanding how a computer works, how to use it safely, and how to type properly. Everything else you learn in Months 2 to 6 depends on getting these basics right.

Month 1 Learning Outcomes

- Identify the parts of a computer and explain what each one does
- Switch a computer on and off correctly
- Use a keyboard and mouse confidently
- Understand the Windows operating system
- Manage files and folders
- Type at a minimum speed of 20 words per minute with good accuracy

Unit 1: Computer Hardware

1.1 What is a Computer?

A computer is an electronic device that processes information. It takes in data (input), processes it, and produces results (output). Computers are used in every industry today — from retail shops to hospitals, schools, and banks.

1.2 Types of Computers

Type	Description	Examples
Desktop	Sits on a desk, separate screen and tower	Office computers, school labs
Laptop	Portable, built-in screen and keyboard	Personal use, business travel
Tablet	Touchscreen, very portable	iPad, Samsung Tab
Smartphone	Pocket-sized, phone + computer	iPhone, Samsung, Tecno

1.3 Main Parts of a Desktop Computer

Input Devices - These go INTO the computer

- Keyboard - used to type text and commands
- Mouse - used to point, click, and navigate
- Microphone - records audio
- Webcam - captures video and photos
- Scanner - converts paper documents to digital files
- USB flash drive - stores and transfers files

Processing

- CPU (Central Processing Unit) - the brain of the computer, processes all instructions
- RAM (Random Access Memory) - temporary memory used while the computer is running
- Motherboard - the main circuit board connecting all components

- Hard Drive / SSD - stores all your files and programs permanently

Output Devices - These come OUT of the computer

- Monitor / Screen - displays images and text
- Speakers - play audio
- Printer - prints documents onto paper
- Projector - displays the screen onto a wall or board

1.4 Caring for Your Computer

1. Keep food and drinks away from the keyboard and screen
2. Never turn off the computer by unplugging it — always shut down properly
3. Keep the computer in a cool, dry, dust-free area
4. Use a surge protector to protect against power surges
5. Clean the screen with a soft, dry cloth — never use water
6. Do not download programmes from unknown websites

Unit 2: The Windows Operating System

2.1 What is an Operating System?

An operating system (OS) is the main software that runs your computer. It manages all the hardware and allows you to run other programmes. The most common operating system is Microsoft Windows. Others include macOS (Apple) and Linux.

In Zimbabwe, most offices and schools use Windows. This course focuses on Windows 10 and Windows 11.

2.2 The Windows Desktop

When you switch on the computer and log in, the first thing you see is the Desktop. Think of it like your physical desk — it is your main working area.

Desktop Element	What it Does
Icons	Shortcuts to programmes and files

Taskbar	The bar at the bottom — shows open programmes and the Start menu
Start Menu	Opens when you click the Windows logo — lets you find programmes
Search Bar	Type here to find any file, programme, or setting quickly
System Tray	Bottom right corner — shows time, Wi-Fi, sound, battery
Recycle Bin	Deleted files go here — empty it to free up space

2.3 Working with Windows

Opening a Programme

1. Click the Start menu (Windows logo at bottom left)
2. Find the programme in the list or type its name in the search bar
3. Click on it to open

Minimise, Maximise, and Close

- Minimise (-) button: hides the window but keeps the programme running
- Maximise (square) button: makes the window fill the whole screen
- Close (X) button: closes the programme completely

Switching Between Open Programmes

- Click on the programme in the taskbar at the bottom of the screen
- Or press Alt + Tab on the keyboard to cycle through open programmes

2.4 Shutting Down Correctly

Always shut down using the proper method. Never just unplug the power — this can damage your files and the hard drive.

1. Close all open programmes
2. Click the Start menu

3. Click the Power button icon
4. Select Shut Down
5. Wait for the screen to go black before turning off the power

Unit 3: Files and Folders

3.1 What are Files and Folders?

A file is a document stored on your computer — it could be a Word document, a photo, a video, or a spreadsheet. A folder is a container that holds files, just like a physical folder in a filing cabinet.

Keeping your files organised in folders is one of the most important habits to develop. A messy computer makes you slow and unprofessional.

3.2 File Explorer

File Explorer is the programme you use to navigate through your files and folders. Open it by clicking the folder icon in the taskbar or pressing Windows + E on the keyboard.

Key Locations in File Explorer

- Desktop - files saved to the desktop
- Documents - the recommended place to save your work files
- Downloads - files downloaded from the internet go here automatically
- Pictures - for photos and images
- This PC - shows all drives including USB drives

3.3 Creating, Renaming, and Deleting Files and Folders

Create a new folder

1. Open File Explorer and navigate to where you want the folder
2. Right-click in an empty space
3. Select New > Folder
4. Type the folder name and press Enter

Rename a file or folder

1. Right-click on the file or folder
2. Select Rename
3. Type the new name and press Enter

Delete a file or folder

1. Right-click on the file or folder
2. Select Delete
3. Confirm deletion

To recover a deleted file, open the Recycle Bin on the desktop, right-click the file, and select Restore.

3.4 Copying and Moving Files

Action	Keyboard Shortcut	What it Does
Copy	Ctrl + C	Makes a duplicate of the file
Cut	Ctrl + X	Moves the file (removes from original location)
Paste	Ctrl + V	Places the copied or cut file in the new location
Undo	Ctrl + Z	Reverses your last action
Select All	Ctrl + A	Selects all files in the current folder

Unit 4: Touch Typing

4.1 Why Typing Speed Matters

In any office job, you will spend hours typing every day. If you type with two fingers while looking at the keyboard, you will be slow and make many mistakes. Touch typing — using all 10 fingers without looking at the keyboard — will make you fast, accurate, and professional.

The goal by end of Month 1 is to type 20 words per minute (wpm) with at least 90% accuracy. Professional typists reach 60-80 wpm. You will get there with practice.

4.2 The Keyboard Layout

The standard keyboard layout is called QWERTY (named after the first 6 letters in the top row). Every keyboard in Zimbabwe uses this layout.

Key Rows

- Number Row: 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 0 (top row)
- Top Row: Q W E R T Y U I O P
- Home Row: A S D F G H J K L (this is your starting position)
- Bottom Row: Z X C V B N M
- Space Bar: the long bar at the bottom, pressed with your thumb

4.3 Finger Placement - The Home Row

The home row is where your fingers rest when you are not typing. This is your default position — your fingers should always return here after pressing any key.

Left Pinky	Left Ring	Left Middle	Left Index	Thumbs
A	S	D	F	Space Bar
Right Index	Right Middle	Right Ring	Right Pinky	
J	K	L	;	

The F and J keys have a small raised bump — these are your index finger home keys. Find them without looking.

4.4 Typing Rules

1. Always return fingers to the home row after each keystroke
2. Never look at the keyboard — look at the screen
3. Sit up straight with both feet flat on the floor

4. Keep your wrists slightly raised, not resting on the desk while typing
5. Use the correct finger for each key — never cheat with the wrong finger
6. Start slowly and build speed gradually — accuracy first, speed second

4.5 Daily Typing Practice Plan

Week	Practice Focus	Target Speed
Week 1	Home row keys only: A S D F G H J K L	10 wpm
Week 2	Add top row: Q W E R T Y U I O P	15 wpm
Week 3	Add bottom row: Z X C V B N M	18 wpm
Week 4	Numbers, punctuation, full sentences	20 wpm

4.6 Free Typing Practice Tools

- TypingClub ([typingclub.com](https://www.typingclub.com)) - structured lessons, free
- Keybr ([keybr.com](https://www.keybr.com)) - adapts to your weak keys
- 10FastFingers ([10fastfingers.com](https://www.10fastfingers.com)) - speed tests

Practice at least 20 minutes every day. Consistency is more important than long sessions.

Month 1 Assessment

Theory Questions (30 marks)

1. Name 3 input devices and explain what each one does. (6 marks)
2. What is the difference between RAM and a hard drive? (4 marks)
3. List the steps to shut down a computer correctly. (4 marks)
4. What is the home row? Name all 8 home row keys. (4 marks)
5. What is File Explorer and what is it used for? (4 marks)
6. Explain the difference between Cut and Copy. (4 marks)

7. Name 2 types of computers and give one use for each. (4 marks)

Practical Assessment (70 marks)

1. Create a folder on the Desktop named 'Month1_YourName'. (5 marks)
2. Inside that folder, create 3 sub-folders: Documents, Pictures, Assignments. (5 marks)
3. Open Notepad and type a paragraph of at least 5 sentences about yourself. Save it as 'About_Me.txt' in your Documents sub-folder. (10 marks)
4. Copy the text file into the Assignments folder. (5 marks)
5. Take a typing speed test and record your result. (10 marks)
6. Rename the text file to 'Bio_YourName.txt'. (5 marks)
7. Demonstrate shutting down and restarting the computer correctly. (10 marks)
8. Open and navigate File Explorer — demonstrate finding the Downloads folder and the Desktop. (10 marks)
9. Show the trainer how to switch between two open programmes using the keyboard. (10 marks)

Month 1 Pass Mark: 60%

You need at least 60 marks out of 100 to pass Month 1 and proceed to Month 2.